NEBRASKA

The Cornhusker State



Sitting at the bend of the Missouri River, Omaha grew into one of the great working cities of the American interior—a place where the railroad arrived early, the stockyards ran wide and loud, and generations of immigrant families built neighborhoods that smelled of bread, garlic, and something always simmering on the stove. It was a city of honest appetites and unpretentious cooking, and it was here, sometime in the 1950s, that the Cheese Frenchee quietly became one of Nebraska's most beloved meals.

The dish has its roots in the French-toasted sandwich tradition that spread through American diners and lunch counters during the mid-twentieth century. But Omaha put its own unmistakable stamp on it. The city's meatpacking industry had drawn waves of Czech, Polish, German, and Italian immigrants into its South Omaha neighborhoods since the late 1800s, and with them came a deep, unshakeable reverence for simple food done with care—good bread, good cheese, nothing wasted, nothing overcomplicated. That spirit was alive in every diner booth and church basement from Dundee to Millard.

The Cheese Frenchee found its most devoted home at Maid Rite and the network of family-owned lunch counters that dotted Omaha's streets mid-century, where working men and women slid onto stools and ordered without looking at the menu because they already knew what they wanted. The sandwich itself was straightforward by design—soft white bread, American or processed cheese melted through the center, the whole thing dipped in an egg batter, rolled in crushed crackers for that distinctive crisp exterior, and dropped into hot oil until golden and bubbling at the edges. It was the kind of food that asked nothing of you except that you eat it while it was hot.

What made it Nebraska's own was never the complexity. It was the consistency—the way it appeared at school cafeterias in Lincoln, at church fundraisers in Norfolk, at family kitchen tables in Kearney and Grand Island. Mothers passed the technique to daughters without writing it down because it didn't need to be written down. It was that simple, and that good. The crunch of the cracker crust giving way to the pull of warm, melted cheese inside is the kind of thing that stays with a person, the kind of food memory that surfaces unexpectedly on a cold January evening when you find yourself reaching for the egg carton before you've even decided to cook.

That is exactly the moment this recipe was made for. Whether you grew up in Nebraska and haven't tasted one in years, or you're encountering it for the first time, the Cheese Frenchee is the rare dish that delivers on every promise. Pull it from the pan golden and crackling, let it rest just long enough not to burn your fingers, and take that first bite—crisp shell, molten center, simple and perfect. Nebraska has known this for decades. Now your kitchen will too.

CHEESE FRENCHEE

There is no loneliness a warm, golden Cheese Frenchee—its buttery crust giving way to a ribbon of molten cheese—cannot, at least for a moment, cure.

Yield: 4 sandwiches

INGREDIENTS

- 8 slices of thick white sandwich bread (day-old is best)
- 8 slices of American cheese (or a mix of American and sharp cheddar)
- 1–2 Tbsp mayonnaise (optional, for spreading inside)
- 2 large eggs
- ½ cup whole milk
- 1 tsp yellow mustard (optional but traditional)
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- 2 cups crushed crackers or cornflakes (finely crushed, but not powdered)
- Vegetable or peanut oil, for frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prepare the sandwiches*: Lay out 8 slices of bread. Spread a thin layer of mayonnaise on 4 slices (optional, for creaminess). Add 2 slices of cheese (or 1 American + 1 sharp cheddar) to each. Top with remaining bread slices to form 4 sandwiches.
2. *Trim & Cut*: Trim crusts from each sandwich. Cut each sandwich diagonally into two triangles. You'll have 8 triangular sandwiches.
3. *Make the batter*: In a shallow bowl, whisk together eggs, milk, mustard, salt, and pepper.
4. *Prepare coating*: Place crushed cornflakes in another shallow dish.
5. *Coat the sandwiches*: Dip each sandwich triangle into the egg mixture, coating completely. Immediately press into the crushed crackers or cornflakes, making sure all sides are well coated.
6. *Fry*: Heat 2–3 inches of oil in a deep skillet or Dutch oven to 350°F (175°C). Fry sandwiches in small batches, 1–2 minutes per side, until golden brown and crispy. Drain on a wire rack or paper towels.
7. *Serve*: Serve immediately while the cheese is gooey and hot, with ketchup or tomato soup for dipping-classic Nebraskan style.

NOTES & TIPS

- Some original versions included a smear of mustard inside along with the cheese.

